The Hijab Face-off

- SHOULD IT BE BANNED IN SCHOOLS?
- IS IT ESSENTIAL TO THE PRACTICE OF ISLAM?
- HOW WILL THE OUTCOME IMPACT THE NATION?

By **SUNIL MENON** WITH **NABILA JAMAL** IN UDUPI

For those to whom the hijab appears as a troubling enigma, it could not have had a more enigmatic wearer than the poet Kamala Das—who converted to Islam for love at age 65 and turned herself into Kamala Surayya. An iconoclast who strung out her inner life in an autobiography shockingly frank on matters of sexuality—so frank that it was censured as a "strip-tease"—ensconced behind the Muslim veil? It was the unlikeliest of controversies to have ruffled India's public life. She passed on in 2009, a mystery wrapped in an enigma, literally. But an unlucky 13 years later, the hijab has been yanked back to centrestage, borne along on a set of seismic events with very many more layers—and vastly higher detonative power. Events that played on the soil of inner and outer lives.



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